Article 4, Section 5 – Immediate Medical Need

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4.05.01 Immediate Medical Need

A. General

This section provides instructions for identification of Medi-Cal immediate need situations and requirements for expediting the immediate need applicants' eligibility determination. MEM 50177

Procedures for issuance of immediate need Medi-Cal ID cards are included in MPG Article 14, Section 2.

MPG LTR 446 (4/01)

B. Background

State DHCS policy requires that when an applicant has an immediate medical need (IMN), the worker must expedite the applicant's eligibility determination. This policy further states that women who are pregnant are automatically considered to have an IMN, whether or not they plan to carry their pregnancy to term. MEPM 4J

These policies are applied equally to all applicants and beneficiaries who have an IMN, including those with OHC or coverage through the County Medical Services (CMS) program or Low-Income Health Program (LIHP). County Policy

MPG LTR 798 (7/13)

C. Definition

An IMN exists when an applicant, or any family member for whom application is made, indicates any of the following conditions or circumstances at any time during the application process:

- pregnancy
- a hospital or nursing home admission is planned within the next ten working days
- a doctor, dentist, clinic, or other medical appointment is scheduled or necessary within the next ten working days and the provider refuses treatment without the Medi-Cal ID card
- a prescription must be filled within the next ten working days
- a referral (HHSA:CMS-5) from a CMS Program Case Manager of from CMS medical staff indicates an immediate need

The applicant's statement of any of the above conditions or circumstances, verbally or otherwise, is to be accepted for purposes of determining that an IMN exists.

MPG LTR 446 (4/01)

4.05.02 Actions Required Upon Identification of IMN

A. Required Actions

Workers and staff assigned to the rescheduling of appointments must be alert to any indication that an IMN exists and reschedule the new appointment within the IMN timeframe. Applicants with an IMN are not required to specifically request that their eligibility determination be expedited. Immediate need procedures, as identified below, are followed whenever an IMN is identified.

MPG LTR 446 (4/01)

B. Pre-application

When an IMN is identified at pre-application, and potential eligibility exists, the applicant must be scheduled for an immediate need intake appointment. Every effort should be made to schedule the immediate need intake appointment as soon as possible within ten working days to permit completion of the eligibility determination in time to meet the specific requirements of the IMN situation.

The worker shall remind the applicant that all required verifications, information, and completed forms must be provided at the intake interview so that an eligibility determination can be made at that time. Cards will be issued the same day for any eligible person with an IMN. If the applicant indicates that any of the required verifications are not available, or that additional assistance with completion of the forms is required due to illiteracy or for other reasons, the applicant will be asked to do the best he/she can and that additional assistance will be provided by available staff.

MEM 50185

County Policy

MPG LTR 446 (4/01)

C. IMN Identified Between Pre-application and Intake

If an applicant with a scheduled intake appointment contacts the reschedule clerk to request an earlier appointment due to an IMN, every effort should be made to provide an earlier appointment.

MPG LTR 446 (4/01)

D. Eligibility Requirements Not Met at Intake

If an IMN was identified at pre-application or during the intake, and the worker is unable to certify eligibility because of missing information/verifications, the worker will review the remaining requirements with the applicant and offer assistance, as necessary, to expedite completion of the eligibility determination.

MPG LTR 446 (4/01)

E. Eligibility Requirements Met at Intake

Once all Medi-Cal eligibility conditions are met, including presumptive factors as appropriate, the worker shall submit a 14-1 HHSA to the MEDS operator for issuance of a Paper ID Card. This includes beneficiaries with a SOC. If the beneficiary already has a valid Benefits Identification Card (BIC), the worker will note on the 14-1 HHSA form "No Card Needed" or "NCN" to alert the MEDS operator to only establish immediate eligibility and not issue a Paper ID Card.

MEM 50743 50745

MPG LTR 446 (4/01)

F. Granted Cases with IMN

Granted beneficiaries who have requested a replacement BIC and have an IMN, which will occur prior to receipt of the state issued replacement BIC, are issued a paper ID Card.

MEPM 4J-1

MPG LTR 446 (4/01)

G. Prior Month Eligibility

An IMN for a prior eligible month is to be processed for any beneficiary when:

- the provider refuses to see the beneficiary until eligibility for a past month's services made available; or
- it has been at least ten months since the month of service and eligibility is needed so that the provider can submit a claim to Medi-Cal within one year of the date of service.

MEM 50746

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